

Readings

John 20:19-31

When it was evening on that day, the first day of the week, and the doors of the house where the disciples had met were locked for fear of the Jews, Jesus came and stood among them and said, "Peace be with you." After he said this, he showed them his hands and his side. Then the disciples rejoiced when they saw the Lord.

But Thomas (who was called the Twin), one of the twelve, was not with them when Jesus came. So the other disciples told him, "We have seen the Lord."

But he said to them, "Unless I see the mark of the nails in his hands, and put my finger in the mark of the spear in his side, I will not believe."

A week later his disciples were again in the house, and Thomas was with them. Although the doors were shut, Jesus came and stood among them and said, "Peace be with you." Then he said to Thomas, "Put your finger here and see my hands. Reach out your hand and put it in my side. Do not doubt but believe."

Thomas answered him, "My Lord and my God!"

Jesus said to him, "Have you believed because you have seen me? Blessed are those who have not seen and yet have come to believe." Now Jesus did many other signs in the presence of his disciples, which are not written in this book. But these are written so that you may come to believe that Jesus is the Messiah, the Son of God, and that through believing you may have life in his name.

Annie Dillard

Pilgrim At Tinker Creek

- adapted

It must be me, I think tonight, that in a certain sense only the newborn in this world are whole, that as adults we are expected to be, and necessarily, somewhat nibbled. It's par for the course. Physical wholeness is not something we have barring accident; it is itself accidental, an accident of infancy....Are the five-foot silver eels that migrate as adults across meadows by night actually scarred with the bill marks of herons, flayed by the sharp teeth of bass? I think of the beautiful sharks I saw from a shore, hefted and held aloft in a light-shot wave. Were those sharks sliced with scars, were there mites in their hides and worms in their hearts? Is our birthright and heritage to be, like Jacob's cattle on which the life of a nation was founded, "ring-streaked, speckled, and spotted"....blotched assaults and quarrying of time? "We are all of us clocks whose faces tell the passing years."

Scars

Show of hands, how many of you have scars? Chances are you have more than one type of scar. Physical scars - marks left from injuries, surgeries, or illnesses. Emotional scars - resulting from losses, betrayals, and wounds of the heart. Spiritual scars - following a major disappointment from your faith community or religious leaders, or distress because your beliefs were not adequate to meet the challenges of the world. Maybe you experienced spiritual abuse or trauma.

What is a scar? It's a permanent mark left after an injury. There was a wound, and some healing has taken place. They come in all shapes and sizes. Some indicate places where there was a tear or separation and we have been stitched back together. Others attest to gaps, losses, holes - places that have healed from the inside out. Most scars are reminders of damage only in their appearance. They don't hurt and they aren't particularly sensitive. They are just visible. Some scars never seem to fully heal; they remain tender to the touch, always a bit raw. And still other scars only make themselves known on particular occasions. I have a scar that never bothers me, unless it's going to rain! Another particular internal scar reminds me once a year of a particular anniversary.

Scars are permanent marks. They reflect our history. They become part of our identity. Think of the FBI "Most Wanted" posters, "Suspect has scar on left cheek."

Scars aren't desirable. Nobody really wants to be scarred. They are marks of pain and distress. Often, we think of scars as ugly and disfiguring. How often have you heard the phrase "unsightly scars," followed by a plug for the latest miracle creams or treatments that would erase your scars. At times I have daydreamed of winning the lottery, and having plastic surgery to remove many of my nasty scars. Medical tourism has become big business. Fly off to sunny Mexico, and get rid of those stretch marks, scars and disfigurements while you're there! Nobody wants to have stars.

And yet... Did you notice in our first reading that Jesus still carries the scars of his crucifixion after his resurrection? Jesus showed the disciples his hands and his side. They saw and touched his scars.

I always figured that if there is a heaven and we have physical bodies, we would return to our very best physical selves. Heck, I'm hoping I'll be the slimmer, taller, younger, and fitter version of Shelley I've always wanted to be. But instead, here's Jesus, after the

resurrection, bearing his scars. And it seems that they were useful. He needed the scars to prove to the disciples present in that house that it really was him, come back to life. Doubting Thomas saw the scars, and doubted no more. Jesus was not a ghost, phantom, or hologram. He was known by his scars.

And we are known by ours. Think about this with me. Your scars tell your story. The physical, mental, and spiritual marks of your injuries tell the tale of your life. What surgeries have you undergone? There are scars. What wars have you survived? There are scars. Where has your heart been broken? What losses have you endured? There are scars. Any place in your living where you have been hurt, abused, damaged, compromised, or wounded, there are scars. Further, our scars reveal our fortitude. They proclaim to the world what we have lived through. They speak silently of our courage, of our ability to endure, and our tenacity. We recover, we heal, we put ourselves together, and with our scars, we continue on.

Years ago, I was surprised by the work of a woman psychologist who specialized in helping those who have been traumatized. Dr. Clarissa Pinkold Estes (*Women Who Run With The Wolves*) had some interesting things to say about scars and a very unique approach to addressing the pains of our past. Listen to what she has to say:

Sometimes in my work with women and men I show them how to make a full-length scape coat from cloth or some other material. A scape coat is a coat that details in painting, writing, and with all manner of things pinned and stitched to it all the name-calling and hurtful things a person has endured in his or her life, all the insults, all the slurs, all the traumas, all the wounds, all the scars. It is that individual's statement of having experienced being scape goated. Sometimes it takes only a day or two to make such a coat, other times it takes months. It is exceedingly helpful in detailing all the hurts and slams and slashes of a person's life.

At first, I made a scapecoat for myself. It soon became so heavy it needed a chorus of Muses to carry the train. I had in mind that I would make this scapecoat and then, having put all this psychic refuse together in one psychic object, I would disperse some of my old woundedness by burning the scapecoat. But you know, I kept the coat hung from the ceiling in the hallway and every time I walked near it, instead of feeling bad, I felt good. I found myself admiring the courage of the woman who could wear such a coat and still be walking foursquare, singing and creating.

I found this also to be true of the people I worked with. They never wanted to destroy their scapecoats once they had made them. They want to keep them forever, the nastier and the gorier, the better. Sometimes we also call them battlecoats, for they are proof of the endurance, the failures, and the victories of individual men and women.

It is also a good idea for a person to count their age, not by years, but by battle scars. "How old are you?" people sometimes ask me. "I am seventeen battle scars old," I say. Usually people don't flinch, and rather happily begin to count up their own battle scar ages accordingly....

Let there be no mistake about it, for you have earned your scars by the hard choices of your life. And although there are scars and plenty of them, it is good to remember that in tensile strength and ability to absorb pressure, a scar is stronger than skin.

It is fascinating to know that the strongest places are the ones that have been wounded and healed. Scars are stronger than regular skin. There is something about a person who has a lot of scars. The person who has been around the block and not had an easy time of it. The individual who has done the internal and external work to rehabilitate and integrate those scars. These are the folks I think that have the most to offer.

This isn't to say that I would wish scars on anyone! It's worth noting though, that injuries, wounds, healings, and scars are part of everyday life.

Annie Dillard deftly reminds us that no one gets out of this life without a scar. The unblemished body, the spot-free spirit, the unmarred psyche are for the very young. She later writes in more detail about sitting in the stillness, drinking in the beauty of nature and noticing how many animals have chewed off ears and lost patches of fur. This is actually the way of nature. Not the perfect pictures we see in calendars and coffee table books.

All these remnants of injury are proof of the tenacity of life. The imprint of past wounds does not tarnish the beauty of the natural world. Instead they remind us that life is hard and just living can be dangerous.

We humans are part of the great interdependent web. Is there really any reason things should be different for us? Instead of thinking of these marks as disfigurements, wrongful impositions on the body

and soul, perhaps we could see them with reverence. If we have truly lived, we will have proof. Some scars are Sacred Scars.

There is the old saying "Time heals all wounds." Not really. Time often covers over our wounds so they aren't so raw and sensitive. And thank goodness for that. Our bodies are wired in such a manner that we begin to heal almost as soon as we are harmed. It is amazing really. If I cut my thumb, my body knows exactly where to send the white blood cells and clotting agents. A scab is formed at just the right spot. In time, new skin has grown over the wound. I might not even have a mark on my thumb to prove I was hurt. Emotional wounds and griefs are similar. We are wired to heal.

There are some injuries that need more than time. They need intentional care. We have to attend to some wounds for them to heal. One of the marks of healing is integration. Think of the word integrity. Something that has integrity is solid and whole. There are no fractures or breaks. It doesn't mean there is no scar, but instead, the pain and the event that caused it have become metabolized. These are the scars that no longer hurt - emotionally as well as physically. Like grief that has been made whole. When we can speak fondly of a lost loved one and not cry, when we can share memories and still feel the love, we have reached a type of integration. We don't pretend or deny the loss and pain. We have moved to a place of healing and our loved one is now part of us. We no longer have to protect our wounds.

Dr. Rachel Namoi Remen, a medical doctor and one of my favorite authors, also became a therapist, specializing in the care of patients dealing with physical illness. She writes of the power of integration in her beautiful story about Clare.

Clare, in her beige linen suit and white silk blouse, appeared flawless, competent, and totally in control when she had first come to see me. It was 8 weeks after undergoing surgery to have her right breast removed. It had been a difficult decision to make with her doctor.

She was in her late twenties, unmarried, and successful as a businesswoman. Until her surgery, she had worked out daily and had been very proud of her body. Men had always found her very attractive, and having a man in her life was important to her. She'd had many lovers, mostly colleagues she had met in the business world. "But that is over now," she said. "I could never allow anyone to see me disfigured like this." After her surgery, she had ended her

relationships with the two men she was seeing. Both of them accepted it gracefully and moved on.

No one at work, none of her friends, not even her parents, suspected that she had cancer. She had done it entirely alone. She told people she was going on a trip to Europe and even had made arrangements to have cards sent to them from abroad. The pressure of keeping this secret became too much, and she needed a place she could talk and be herself. So she started seeing me. She told me, "I can't come very often. People would begin to suspect." "Come whenever you need to," I said.

For the next few years, we would meet every three or four months. On the surface, her life was as it had been, except that she lived as a celebate, putting all her energy into her work. I asked if she planned to live this way for the rest of her life. "Only for five years." Clare had made plans with a very good and very conservative surgeon to have breast reconstruction surgery after she had been cancer free for five years. "After five years, the chances are that I will be home free."

About a year before this important anniversary, during one of our sessions, Clare mentioned that she struck up a conversation with a painter who she met at an art gallery opening. She agreed to have coffee with him because she liked talking to him and because he was "obviously totally unsuitable as a lover." She thought maybe they could become friends.

Over time, Peter's name came up more and more in Clare's sessions. She was impressed by his work, met many of his friends and it surprised her to discover that she fit in so well. Then came a phone call, asking me for an urgent visit. She came in looking somber. "It's the end," she said. Thinking that perhaps she had suffered a recurrence, my heart jumped into my throat. But this is not what she had meant at all. Peter had left her a voice mail asking her to go away for the weekend. "I will have to tell him now," she said. "It's over."

I suggested that once Peter knew of her surgery, they could continue their relationship with more freedom. "No," Clare explained. "Beauty is his whole life. He will be repulsed." She was going to tell him at dinner that evening. "Call if you need to." I said.

Peter wanted to be more than friends. Clare refused, telling him that her body was too ugly, too maimed. But maybe after her surgery, which was only six months away...

Clare had scheduled the surgery more than a year ago. She had started saving money right after her mastectomy. It would be

expensive and difficult, but she hoped it would return her to wholeness.

I didn't see Clare again until a few days before her fifth anniversary. When she came in, she looked excited and happy. This was a big milestone and when I asked her about the upcoming surgery, Clare smiled and told me she had canceled it. I was stunned. "How come?"

Clare looked at her for a long moment. Then slowly she unbuttoned her blouse and shrugged it off her shoulders. She was not wearing a bra, and her left breast was exquisite. But its beauty was overshadowed by the radical change in her body. Her Mastectomy scar had been covered over with a mass of tiny, exquisite tattooed flowers. They looked real. In the most delicate of pastel shades, they climbed to the top of her right shoulder. As she turned away, the flowers fell across it and down her back as it scattered by gravity or the wind. She stood, pulling her slacks down over her hips. Her body was beautiful. One little tattooed flower had come to rest in the small of her back, and another lay against her right buttock. Under it was a tiny initial "P."

My mouth dropped open in shock and at the same time, and I experienced a pang of envy. She was indescribably erotic. Men encountered women like her only in their dreams.

Shrugging back into her blouse and buttoning her slacks, she sat down again, laughing at my astonishment. "Isn't it beautiful? Peter painted it and we went to Amsterdam to have it done. Then we used the money I had saved for the surgery for a honeymoon. I am so happy!" She was blushing slightly. "My husband has convinced me beyond the shadow of a doubt that anything of real beauty is one of a kind."

Rachel Naomi , M.D.

My Grandfather's Blessings

- adapted

Look at your own scars. They speak of your life and your story. They show your strength and resilience. They mark where you have been wounded and how you have healed. And in a surprising way, your scars may be sacred and beautiful.

Amen and amen.

